THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #007

MARC LOU BUILT 35 STARTUPS. ABOUT FIVE OF THEM WORKED

A French founder was fired, moved to Bali with about $20,000 and started shipping small products in public. One of them made over a million dollars and has since faded by more than 80 percent. He saw it coming and had already built its replacement.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Marc Lou (Marc Louvion), Solo founder
COMPANY	ShipFast, CodeFast, DataFast and TrustMRR
FOUNDED	2023 (ShipFast)
HQ	Remote (company registered in Singapore)
SECTOR	Developer tools, courses, analytics and a startup marketplace
STAGE	Bootstrapped, solo
FUNDING	None reported
MODEL	One-time products, now shifting to subscriptions and a marketplace

Hello again, and welcome to File #007. Thank you for reading.

In the thirty days to 11 August 2026, a piece of software called ShipFast made $3,537. That is a perfectly nice amount of money for a side project. It's a strange amount for ShipFast, which has taken in more than a million dollars, made its creator famous, and was earning over $20,000 a month as recently as last December.

Its creator isn't worried. He told you it would happen, and by the time it did, he had already built the thing that replaced it.

His name is Marc Lou. He is French, he works alone, and he has launched roughly 35 small businesses. By his own count around five have worked. This week's file is about what it looks like to run a business that way: to treat products as experiments, to publish the results, and to move on before a winner dies. It's also about how he now builds, which is mostly by telling an AI what to write. (All figures are in US dollars, and unless we say otherwise they are his own.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Marc Louvion, known online as Marc Lou, a French solo founder who builds in public.
- **What:** a rotating portfolio. ShipFast is a starter kit that saves developers weeks of set-up. CodeFast is a coding course for beginners. DataFast is analytics that tell you which visitors turn into paying customers. TrustMRR is a database of verified startup revenue that has grown into a marketplace for buying and selling small startups.
- **Why it matters:** it's the clearest worked example we know of a portfolio approach, where most things fail, a few pay for everything, and the founder's real skill is knowing when to move.
- **The number to remember:** about five in 35. That's his own estimate of his hit rate.

THE FOUNDER

By his own telling, Marc spent years getting nowhere. His site says that in 2018 he worked on a single startup for a whole year, got zero users, and burned out. Profiles of him describe roughly four years of side projects that never passed $3,000 a month.

Then, in November 2021, he was fired. According to Remarkable Magazine he had been working in marketing for the American internet personality Tai Lopez. He had about $20,000 in savings and no plan, so he moved to Bali, where $20,000 lasts longer, and started building things.

This time he did two things differently. He kept the products small, so each one took days or weeks to build. And he posted everything he did on X as he did it: the launches, the numbers, the flops.

In two years he shipped 16 or 17 products, depending on who is counting. Most went nowhere. Some flopped inside a week. But the audience grew with each one, and people seemed to enjoy watching the flops as much as the wins.

THE PRODUCT THAT PAID FOR EVERYTHING

By the summer of 2023 Marc had noticed something about his own work. Every time he started a new product he built the same things first: the sign-in, the payment page, the emails, the database, the landing page. He had now done that about sixteen times.

So he packaged it. ShipFast went on sale on 1 September 2023. It is a "boilerplate": a ready-made skeleton of a web app, with all the tedious parts already done, so a developer can start on the idea itself on day one.

Here is why it worked:

- **He was the customer.** He'd felt the pain sixteen times. He knew exactly what to include.

- **His audience was the customer too.** By then tens of thousands of people followed him, and most of them were developers who wanted to ship things quickly.
- **The timing was good.** The tools ShipFast is built on were becoming the default choice for small web projects just as it launched.
- **It was sold once.** Launch prices were $49 and $69, with no subscription.

Streakr, quoting Marc, puts the launch month at about $40,000. Starter Story reported $528,000 in the first four months. Product Hunt named him its Maker of the Year for 2023. ShipFast's own page now claims about 8,400 customers, at a price that has risen to around $200.

For a while it was most of his income. By August 2024 his X profile was advertising "$62K/m".

THE CURVE

Products that are sold once tend to follow a curve. There's a launch wave. There's a long tail, fed by the founder's audience. And then there's a decline, as everyone who wants one has bought one and competitors pile in.

Marc publishes his revenue, so we can watch the curve happen. These are monthly figures from his own Stripe-connected dashboard:

MONTH	SHIPFAST	CODEFAST	DATAFAST	TRUSTMRR
December 2025	$20,281	$22,267	$16,187	$22,883
March 2026	$9,463	$8,268	$21,306	$31,921
June 2026	$3,338	$9,788	$21,487	$28,603
July 2026	$4,832	$6,682	$27,158	$42,373

Read the first column downwards and ShipFast falls by more than 80 percent in six months. Read the last two columns downwards and you can see why he isn't panicking.

In June 2025, ShipFast was about 40 percent of his monthly income. A year later it was about 3.5 percent, and his total was still above $80,000 a month.

THE MOVE TO SUBSCRIPTIONS

The first two columns of that table are products you buy once. The second two are products people pay for every month, and they are deliberate.

DataFast came out of his own irritation. Ordinary website analytics tell you how many people visited. They don't tell you which of those visitors paid. DataFast connects the two, so a founder can see that, say, a YouTube video brought in $900 and a Reddit post brought in nothing. It took about four months to reach its first $1,000 a month, which for someone with his audience is slow. He kept going. By the end of 2025 he put it at $15,800 a month and

growing 14 percent monthly, with close to 1,000 paying customers.

Its marketing is built in. “Users do the marketing by sharing screenshots of their analytics,” he wrote.

TrustMRR came from a different irritation: people posting fake revenue screenshots. Marc built a site where a founder connects their payment account and the site displays their real revenue, checked hourly against the payment provider. He built the first version in about 24 hours.

It wasn’t an instant success in the usual sense. He has written that he tried ten different versions of the idea and that nine failed. The one that worked was a marketplace. If you can prove a small startup’s revenue, you can sell it. The marketplace opened in December 2025, and he says a dozen startups changed hands in the first two weeks. By July 2026 TrustMRR was his biggest earner, and in October his X profile reportedly listed it at $53,000 a month.

A third new line appeared in 2026. **Ship or Die** is a paid community he reportedly runs with another founder, Jack Friks. Members pay a one-time fee and commit to launching a startup every 30 days, or they’re out. One profile lists it at $15,000 in June.

HOW HE BUILDS NOW

When we first looked into Marc, we couldn’t find him saying anything specific about AI tools. We kept looking, and he has.

On 7 March 2025 he posted that Cursor’s AI agent was “my AI co-founder”. (Cursor is a code editor with an AI assistant built in.) He called it his designer, because he uploads pictures of what he wants. He called it his product manager, and also his marketer, since it writes the sales copy straight into the code. Then came the line that matters: “Now with MCP, 90% of my code output is written by AI. All I do is prompt engineering & code review.”

MCP is a standard that lets an AI assistant use outside tools and data. In practice it means the AI can look things up and act, and doesn’t only write text.

A year later, in an April 2026 interview with Starter Story, he described where that had led. “Right now my setup is the most boring setup ever,” he said: a code editor on one side, a chat with an AI on the other, one conversation at a time. He said he had shipped about 300 features on his marketplace in three months, and six new apps so far that year. (The transcript is machine-generated, and it doesn’t name the editor or the model, so we won’t.)

What he said next is the useful part for the rest of us. When building gets this cheap, he argued, the measure of a founder doesn’t change. “It’s still the number of things you ship.”

THE HONEST PART: FAILURE

Marc’s hit rate is the thing we’d most like you to remember, because he is unusually open about it and most people aren’t.

In that same April interview he said he had built 35 startups and that “the hit rate is about 5”. His review of 2025 names names. He launched three new products that year. BioAge failed. ClipMarc failed. The third was still under wraps. That’s the same year he made over a million dollars.

His comment on it was dry: “A good reminder that having an audience doesn’t guarantee a successful startup!”

His income for 2025 was $1,032,000, which he noted was 20 percent less than 2024. He put that in the headline of his own newsletter, and we respect him for it.

WHAT TO KNOW ABOUT THE NUMBERS

Marc publishes more than almost anyone, and we’ve relied on that. There are still four things you should know before you repeat any of his figures.

- **It is all self-reported.** Everything comes from his posts, his newsletter, his website and his dashboards.
- **He owns the verifier.** TrustMRR is the tool he built to prove revenue is real. His own revenue is proven through it, and it’s now his biggest product. That doesn’t make any number false. It does mean nobody independent has checked.
- **Two of his own sources disagree.** His personal page puts ShipFast’s lifetime revenue at about $1.09 million. TrustMRR shows $1.27 million. He hasn’t explained the $180,000 difference.
- **Headline and recurring are different things.** His page has led with about $108,000 a month while his dashboard showed about $43,800 of true recurring revenue. The rest is one-time sales, which have to be won again every month. When anyone quotes you a monthly figure, ask which kind it is.

His reported monthly total through 2026 has run between about $77,000 and $98,000, depending on the month and the source.

THE WEEK IT WENT WRONG

In October 2024 another developer reported a security flaw in one of Marc’s products, first privately and then, getting no reply, in public. More reports followed, including one showing how to get past a paywall.

Marc’s first public response was dismissive. Dozens of people try to break his sites every day, he wrote, and they always call it a critical vulnerability. The community didn’t like that, and other developers started a public audit of his products.

Two days later he apologised and said fixes were on the way. Reaction was mostly forgiving. We couldn’t confirm exactly what was fixed, or whether existing ShipFast buyers received the fixes.

It was an expensive lesson for him. When you have no users you can get away with shipping fast and fixing later. Once thousands of people have paid, some of whom have built their own businesses on your code, you can't.

WHAT MADE IT POSSIBLE

- **An audience built over years.** Every launch starts with thousands of developers watching. He says his newsletter passed 51,000 readers in January 2026.
- **Low costs.** He has no employees, and he started in Bali on $20,000.
- **A tolerance for public failure** that most people simply don't have.
- **Cheap building.** AI now writes most of his code, so the cost of an experiment keeps falling.

The first of those takes years. The other three are choices.

Try this

Package what you've built three times. Look back over your last few projects. What did you rebuild from scratch each time? A checklist, a template, a spreadsheet, a bit of code? That could be a product, and the people you already work with are its first customers.

Set the kill rule before you start. Decide in advance how long a new idea gets and what it has to earn. Marc tried ten versions of one idea and dropped nine.

Ask whether a sale is once or monthly. If everything you sell is bought once, your income resets every month. Start the recurring product while the one-time product is still doing well.

Count what you ship. For one month, track how many things you put in front of real customers, however small. That's his measure, and it's a good one.

Have someone else check your numbers. If you publish revenue, use a method you don't own, or say clearly that you own it.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

The audience is the business. Every product he has depends on his following on X and his newsletter. If the platform changes or his reach falls, everything falls with it.

One-time products decay. ShipFast and CodeFast are both shrinking. The plan depends on DataFast and TrustMRR continuing to grow.

A marketplace runs on trust. TrustMRR is only worth something if people believe its numbers. A disputed listing, or a serious question about the owner verifying his own revenue, could damage it quickly.

Speed against safety. With AI writing 90 percent of the code and one person reviewing it, the October 2024 problem could come back in a bigger form.

Most things fail. Thirty of his 35 did. If you copy the method you get his failure rate along with it.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **The subscription lines.** Do DataFast and TrustMRR keep growing as ShipFast fades?
2. **Completed deals.** Do startups actually get bought and sold through TrustMRR, in volume?
3. **An outside check.** Does anyone independent ever confirm the figures?
4. **Ship or Die.** Is it a lasting business, or another experiment that gets cut?

After he was fired he spent years building things nobody wanted. Then he built one thing thousands of people wanted, watched it fade, and wasn't surprised. About thirty of his products are gone, and he's still shipping new ones.

That's File #007. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #008 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Marc Lou's own newsletter, posts, website and dashboards, a Starter Story interview, and press and compilations we label as secondary. We haven't verified any revenue figure independently and we haven't spoken to him. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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